

Episode 39: Setting Aside "Colour Direction" for a Bit to Talk About *Hakaba Kitaro*

Man, Tokyo's been having cold days that really feel like the depths of winter.

Every year around this time, during the Centre Test period (when I was a high school student, it was still called the "Common First-Stage Test"), Tokyo would always get snow, but it hasn't snowed for the past several years, has it? This year too, the Meteorological Agency forecast snow, but my expectations (laugh) were betrayed and it ended in disappointment. But cold days are still continuing, so I'd like to wait in anticipation.

Tokyo hasn't had much real snow lately. I'd like it to accumulate enough for snowball fights at least once a year. As a snow lover, it's quite lonely. Ah, I want to see snow. I want to go play somewhere snowy—an outdoor hot spring while snow is falling would be the ultimate... such are my fantasies and desperate wishes these days (laugh).

But if I took a break now, I'd probably get killed. I'm super busy being chased by *Hakaba Kitaro* work and coming home in the early morning almost every day. What surprised me about working on a TV series again after so long was the fact that "Why is one week so short?!" (bitter laugh). Ah, there's way too little time! But I'm in the middle of very enjoyable days.

Well then.

I really should be continuing the story about "Colour Direction" credits... but I'm too busy with actual work to properly take time to write the manuscript (crying). Sorry about that.

So I'll write a little about *Hakaba Kitaro* instead. I'll talk a bit about the opening and ending that I couldn't write about two episodes ago.

Hakaba Kitaro is currently airing to great acclaim in Fuji TV's late-night "NoitaminA" slot, and following the first episode's 4.8% rating, episode 2 was an amazing 4.9%! The producer and director are getting all excited saying "Let's aim for 10%!" (laugh), and thanks to this good start, the broadcast area is steadily expanding. Man, I'm really happy!

For this opening and ending, director Nakamura Kenji from *Mononoke* handled the storyboard and direction. The key animation—or rather, all the animation—was done by Hashimoto Takafumi, also from *Mononoke*. The art was by Magic House, special effects by Hoshino-kun from Toei Animation, and photography by Tatsunoko Pro's photography department.

That opening uses panels from Mizuki-sensei's original manga as motifs, but everything was redrawn by Hashimoto-san, and moreover, it was essentially done in one take with marker pens. Amazing! We scanned those and had the finishing staff do the base colours, then I worked on determining the colour tones while painting. Hashimoto-san's animation work took 4 days, overlapping with my work period of 3 days, then 2 days for photography. From completed storyboard to finished photography, it was an ultra-short decisive battle of just one week! (laugh) By the way, why it became such a short decisive battle is a secret! (bitter laugh)

As viewers can tell, the photography is essentially one-cut processing, including the live-action parts at the end. Same with the ending. When the rushes came up, there was a pleasant murmur in the screening room (laugh). Since so few people were involved in the work, nobody knew the content. Even those of us who were involved were surprised by how it turned out.

For the ending, we actually reshoot it every episode. The text flowing on screen is different each time (laugh). I also determine the colours and make replacements for each episode.

Director Nakamura and I had been saying "We'd like to do something together" whenever we met for a long time, and finally, that wish came true this time. Yeah, it was great. I'd like to do something interesting together again (laugh) > Director Nakamura

The opening and ending we made this way turned out to be quite interesting, I think.

So please watch this week too, everyone!

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